

Blazing a Trail

Shefali Goradia is confident that her taking on the leadership at Deloitte South Asia will encourage other women to follow suit

BY SURABHI

SHEFALI GORADIA, A gold medalist and all-India CA topper with over 35 years of experience in international tax, is seen as a trailblazer and a leading authority in her field. She took charge as Chairperson of Deloitte South Asia in April 2023, becoming the first woman to be elected as chair of a Big 4 firm in India.

While tax remains her first love, she is excited about the learning curve and is enjoying her new role. Her work now has a much wider spectrum, including oversight and stewardship of Deloitte in South Asia, leading the Global

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"A lot of women have an imposter syndrome, and we often feel that we are never ready for the job," says Goradia, who has mentored several women over the years, encouraging them to raise their hands for leadership positions. So when the opportunity came, she took the plunge. "I said, it was...

SHEFALI GORADIA

56, Chairperson, Deloitte South Asia



now or never, and even if I don't know all aspects of it, I will learn along the way," she says, adding that she too has been fortunate to be mentored and has had the support from many network firms. "There are also many senior women in leadership in Deloitte globally, and they share their experiences, and they are more than willing to show how they've navigated in their journey to help in whatever way they can."

Goradia, who joined Deloitte in 2017 after stints with Arthur Andersen, Nishith Desai Associates, and BMR, takes this spirit of inclusivity seriously. Deloitte offers benefits beyond flexi working hours to women. For instance, it has a reimbursement programme that refunds the expenses of hiring a nanny by women employees who have children. Under its WAVE programme, all board members and the wider senior leadership are expected to mentor and advocate for high potential women professionals who are stepping into leadership roles. "A woman's career is the first thing that goes out of the window when there are family pressures," she points out, adding that this is now changing.

With an effervescent smile and her can-do attitude, Goradia is hopeful that she sets an example for other women as well. After all, she did learn Sanskrit and how to play basketball during the pandemic! **BT**

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